Col Hemant, AQMG; and Maj Sameer, AAG, got right down to it. The first task was to apportion whatever buildings there were at Phulbari between the HQ and the Battalion, making sure that both got a mix of good and bad buildings. The CO of 10 MADRAS, Col R Mutalik was most cooperative and even offered to move out of his hut (residence would be too grand a word) to make way for me. The HQ was totally dependent on 10 MADRAS for food, water, clothing and shelter, since we did not have anything of our own. Our men dined in their *langar*, JCOs in their JCOs' Mess and officers in their Officers' Mess. Over the course of the next months, the complete set of stores as per the War Establishment Tables kept pouring in, and we were able to slowly and steadily wean ourselves away from 10 MADRAS. 7 BIHAR, commanded by Col Negi, chipped in too, by giving us on loan whatever they could spare; tables, chairs, furnishings, crockery and cutlery—our wish list was bottomless. The men of the Brigade, the Brigade Camp, were from the Bihar Regiment. The Brigade Subedar Major (SM) had come on promotion from 16 BIHAR, which was at Leh. That summer, there was a freak cloudburst at Leh, which triggered a massive mudslide that swept half of 16 BIHAR away. The CO of the unit wrote to all the Bihar units and HQ requesting financial assistance. What could we give? We were ourselves a new raising with not a penny to our name. Providentially, the Corps HQ sent us a cheque of Rs 10,000 for our welfare fund. We encashed this cheque in our newly opened account and made out a fresh one in favour of 16 BIHAR. Their need was greater than ours.

Being a new raising did not mean that we did not have an operational role, which is our bread and butter. There was so much to be done and hardly enough hours in the day to do it all. We decided to make two teams; an operations team with me

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